University of St.Gallen

Course and Examination Fact Sheet: Spring Semester 2026

8,223: Managing Partnerships Strategically: Alliances, Platforms and Ecosystems

ECTS credits: 4

Overview examination/s

(binding regulations see below)
decentral - Active participation, Analog, Individual work individual grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Presentation, Analog, Group work group grade (50%)
Examination time: Term time
decentral - Software application, Digital, Group work group grade (25%)
Examination time: Term time

Attached courses

Timetable -- Language -- Lecturer
8,223,1.00 Managing Partnerships Strategically: Alliances, Platforms and Ecosystems -- English -- Lechner Christoph

Course information

Prerequisites

None.

Learning objectives

1. Students will be able to outline the fundamental principles of strategically managing partnerships in the forms of alliances, platforms, and ecosystems.
2. Students will be able to contrast the most prominent academic constructs and theories around alliances, platforms, and ecosystems.
3. Students will be able to measure the success of strategic partnerships from a management perspective.
4. Students will be able to propose improvements for the strategic management of partnerships like alliances, platforms, and ecosystems.

Content

Strategic partnerships of various types and forms have increased strongly in popularity over the last years. In a volatile, uncertain, complex, and ambiguous world, new means of strategizing around these collaborative forms are necessary.

The number of such collaborations has dramatically increased. Strategic alliances have recently surpassed the number of M&A transactions per year. More than 26'000 new strategic alliances are founded annually. A particularly interesting phenomenon in collaborative strategy is the emergence of ecosystems within and across industries, sometimes even creating new ones. With the rise of digital platforms, this development has gained new momentum. These (meta-) organizational forms connect players to share digital content, like on *YouTube*, or to trade goods, like in case of the chemical-based platform *CheMondis*, or the home and living platform *Westwing*.

Today, six out of the ten largest firms worldwide according to market capitalization base their operations on a digital platform business. Strategy scholars acknowledge that success by researching how these collaborative arrangements can be created, managed, and sustained. Although we often see smart and profitable examples, we also observe many failures, losing substantial amounts of resources during the pursuit of successful collaboration. Navigating such an environment is challenging and requires new ways of strategic thinking. Many companies suffer from a lack of capable talent to fill roles in the

management of such strategic partnerships. This course aims at training students to build strengths in the field of managing partnerships strategically while being adaptive to new developments.

Structure and indications of the learning and teaching design

Didactically, we structure the course in three blocks:

- The first block focuses on alliances and comprises two sessions. These encompass an introduction to strategic alliances, their formation, execution, compilation, and termination.
- The second block focuses on platforms and ecosystems and comprises four sessions. These encompass the introduction to the topic, assessment of the macro-environmental factors, definition of the value proposition, design, scale-up, monetization, and value capture.
- The third block focuses on the assessment and comprises two sessions. These encompass the Harvard Business School in-class simulation and the group presentations.

Your journey in this class will entail three elements, namely learning, interaction, and transfer. Your active involvement will be critical to the learning outcome of this course.

Learning

- We start every learning session with a brief introduction to the topic by the lecturer.
- You will also receive a set of slides and selected articles that are helpful for your learning.
- You are encouraged to actively search in databases or general outlets for valuable information.

Interaction

- This element of your learning journey has the purpose of reflecting on your knowledge, filling gaps, complementing, and enhancing your understanding of each session's topics.
- We invite practitioners to share their expertise in-class during various guest lectures.
- We encourage you to stimulate in-class discussions on challenges related to the course content and induce further insights for your fellow students.

Transfer

- We will confront you with specific managerial challenges related to the material of each session.
- You will work on these challenges alone or together with your peers.

Please note that this course is designed to encourage interactions. Our role is to support you in your learning process, trigger interesting debates, propose novel approaches, and coach your transfer activities. You and your actions finally determine the outcome and quality of this course. The more you invest, the more you will learn.

Literature

Required literature will be indicated in the syllabus.

Additional information

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Examination information

Examination sub part/s

1. Examination sub part (1/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Active participation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Individual work individual grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
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Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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2. Examination sub part (2/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Presentation
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Oral examination
Examination mode	Analog
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Asynchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	50%
Duration	--

Languages
Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark
In-class group presentation

Examination-aid rule
Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids
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3. Examination sub part (3/3)

Examination modalities

Examination type	Software application
Responsible for organisation	decentral
Examination form	Practical test
Examination mode	Digital
Time of examination	Term time
Examination execution	Synchronous
Examination location	On Campus
Grading type	Group work group grade
Weighting	25%
Duration	--

Languages

Question language: English
Answer language: English

Remark

Harvard Business School in-class simulation

Examination-aid rule

Free aids provision

Basically, students are free to choose aids. Any restrictions are defined by the faculty members in charge of the examination under supplementary aids.

Supplementary aids

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Content

The active participation component of your final grade will depend on the quality of your contributions during class. This requires thorough preparation and the active participation in in-class discussion and case exercises.

For the presentation component of your final grade, you will team up with a group of fellow students from the course to work on a shared topic. More details on the topic will follow in the first session in class.

The software application component of your final grade will be a Harvard Business School simulation game that we will run in class. In tandems, your abilities to apply your previously gained knowledge will be assessed.

Literature

Required literature will be indicated in the course syllabus.

Please note

Please note that only this fact sheet and the examination schedule published at the time of bidding are binding and takes precedence over other information, such as information on StudyNet (Canvas), on lecturers' websites and information in lectures etc.
Any references and links to third-party content within the fact sheet are only of a supplementary, informative nature and lie outside the area of responsibility of the University of St.Gallen.

Documents and materials are only relevant for central examinations if they are available by the end of the lecture period (CW21) at the latest. In the case of centrally organised mid-term examinations, the documents and materials up to CW 13 (Monday, 23rd March 2026) are relevant for testing.

Binding nature of the fact sheets:

- Course information as well as examination date (organised centrally/decentrally) and form of examination: from bidding start in CW 04 (Thursday, 22nd January 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for decentralised examinations: in CW 12 (Monday, 16 March 2026);
- Examination information (supplementary aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised mid-term examinations: in CW 14 (Monday, 30 March 2026);
- Examination information (regulations on aids, examination contents, examination literature) for centrally organised examinations: two weeks before ending with de-registration period in CW 15 (Monday, 06 April 2026).